Managing Unaccompanied or Displaced Minors and Reports of a Missing Child at a Shelter

Guidance on necessary actions workers in shelters must take to protect unaccompanied, displaced and missing children

Typically performed by: Shelter Site Manager
Roles likely to support task: HQ Reunification Manager, HQ Sheltering Manager, Shelter Shift Supervisors, Client Care section, Integrated Care Condolence Team

Considerations

- The Shelter Site Manager must immediately prioritize safety and reunification efforts for unaccompanied or displaced minors in shelter
- Disaster Mental Health workers are to provide parents or guardians seeking a *missing child* compassion and information on resources.
- Every effort must be made to make these children feel welcome and safe, and to ensure their privacy is protected.
- The law and our **Fundamental Principles** require that this guidance is followed with sensitivity and close attention to detail.
- Shelter Site Managers are responsible for the care of unaccompanied minors in our shelters until law enforcement or the designated child welfare agency formally takes custody.
- Law enforcement or the official child welfare agency is then responsible for these children until they are reunited with parents or lawful guardians.
- Related Shelter Activity Standards:
    - Shelter Site Operations Standards

Definitions

- An *Unaccompanied Minor* is a person under the age defined by state law* who has been separated from parents, legal guardians, and other relatives; **and** who is not being cared for by an adult who, by law or custom, is responsible for doing so.
    - **Depending on the state or territory, this age may be 18, 19, or 21 years old. State law should be consulted.*
- A *Displaced Minor* is a child without their *customary* primary caregiver (both parents and legal guardian) who is in the company of an adult relative or other adult who, by law or custom, is responsible for their care (licensed childcare provider, schoolteacher, nanny, etc.).

What to Do When a Minor Arrives at the Shelter Without Their Parent or Guardian

Provide immediate care, comfort and for all children who arrive without parents or a legal guardian

- Determine if the child needs emergency medical care and, if so, call 911.
- Engage the Client Care section to meet non-emergency medical or mental health needs.
    - Offer the child water and a snack and create an environment for them to feel safe.
- Be patient, understanding and calm. Do not increase the stress of the minor by discussing the disaster.

Ensure Minor Is Supervised

For an Unaccompanied Minor

- Assign two shelter workers to supervise the minor. If needed, reassign, the tasks typically performed by these workers.
- The two assigned shelter workers continue to supervise the unaccompanied minor until law enforcement or social service/child services agency arrives and officially take custody.

For a Displaced Minor

- A displaced minor does not require supervision by assigned Red Cross workers. While the minor has been separated from their parents or legal guardian, they are in the care of an adult who typically has responsibility for their welfare (for example, coach, teacher, another adult family member, childcare provider).

Gather Information to Assist with Reunification

- If possible, take the minor to a quiet, private space or room. When settled, talk with the minor to gather the information listed below. *Do not assume the information the child provides is accurate or that they will be able to answer all your questions.*
    - Minor's full name and any nicknames
    - Name of minor's parents or guardian and their phone number(s)
    - Minor's date of birth or approximate age
    - Where and when they were found and/or became separated from their parent or guardian (including location, date, time)
    - Note the minor's:
        - *Sex and gender*
        - *Hair and eye color*
        - Clothing they were wearing when they arrival at the shelter
        - How they arrived at the shelter (if known)

Document and Report

- The Shelter Site Manager or designee must contact local law enforcement and be prepared to provide the following information:
    - Identify yourself as a Red Cross worker and that you are calling to report a child at our shelter without parents or guardian
    - Note the officer's contact information, and date and time of call, in the Shelter Manager's Log
    - Request information about local jurisdiction procedures for an unaccompanied child
    - Provide the information given by the minor

- Register the minor on the National Center for Missing and Exploited Children (NCMEC) using either the website or by telephone.
    - **https://umr.missingkids.org/umr**
    - 1-800-THE-LOST (1-800-843-5678)

- Note date and time report was filed in the Shelter Manager's Log
    - Inform the HQ Sheltering Manager of steps taken

- HQ Sheltering Manager informs the HQ Reunification Manager, Mass Care Chief and Assistant Director of Operations.
- Work with internal stakeholders (HQ Sheltering Manager, HQ Reunification Manager, HQ Client Care Manager) and external stakeholders (law enforcement, applicable child welfare agency, and National Center for Missing and Exploited Children) to determine a transfer/reunification plan.
- Work with HQ Sheltering Manager or HQ Reunification Manager to search other shelter locations for the child's parent/guardian.

When working with these children, keep in mind the following:

- If any individual removes the child without presence of law enforcement, notify law enforcement immediately.
- Only law enforcement, the identified child welfare agency, or NCMEC should be permitted to photograph unaccompanied minors or displaced children. All information about a child should be handled confidentially.

What to Do When Someone at a Shelter Reports a Missing Child

- Show empathy and acknowledge their situation; act calmly but with a sense of urgency
- Determine the specific relation of the adult to the sought child (for example, parent, other relation, legal guardian.)
- Encourage the reporting person to contact local law enforcement. Prepare them to be able to provide the following information about the child to authorities:
    - Name
    - Date of birth
    - Sex/Gender
    - Height and weight
    - Hair and eye color
    - Any unique identifiers (birthmarks, injury, eyeglasses, braces, etc.)
    - When and where the child was last seen
    - What they were wearing when last seen
- Recommend that they ask law enforcement to enter the child's information into the FBI's National Crime Information Center's Missing Persons File.
- Encourage them to contact the National Center for Missing and Exploited Children (NCMEC)
    - 1-800-THE-LOST (1-800-843-5678)
    - Let them know there is also a search tool:
        - **https://www.missingkids.org/gethelpnow/search**
    - Inform the HQ Sheltering Manager that a client has reported a missing child
        - The HQ Sheltering Manager will provide the HQ Reunification Manager with the client's name and contact information so they can create a *Sought Person Case*.
    - Inform Client Care section or Integrated Care Condolence Team of the report.

Related Articles

Sheltering Toolkit
Resources for Red Cross workers supporting the sheltering activity during readiness and shelter operations

American Red Cross and the National Center for Missing and Exploited Children MOU
Details the relationship between the American Red Cross and the National Center for Missing and Exploited Children (NCMEC)

Questions

For assistance contact **Sheltering@redcross.org**

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